Power, violence & guilt

Gain the crown

1 Ambition with awareness

Macbeth knows duties as relative, subject and host. "Vaulting ambition" (1.7) pictures overreaching and a fall.

His hesitation establishes responsibility: he understands objections before choosing the crime.

2 Violence escalates

Defends Scotland → murders a sleeping guest → hires Banquo's killers → attacks Macduff's family.

Violence changes from public service to private security and then cruelty.

Fear does not excuse the decisions it helps explain.

Pay the price

3 Blood changes meaning

Blood on hands — Stain in the mind

Early blood proves bravery. After Duncan's murder it becomes evidence and moral contamination.

"Neptune's ocean" (2.2): hyperbole makes guilt seem impossible to cleanse. Macbeth imagines staining the sea.

4 Sleep & washing

Murdering sleep suggests destroying innocence and peace. Lady Macbeth's confident "little water" fails in the long term.

Repeated hand-rubbing in 5.1 makes inner guilt visible. Her command cannot remove an imagined stain.

Link the early claim to its later reversal.

Judge the outcome

5 Kingship vs tyranny

Duncan rewards others; Macbeth protects himself by attacking them. "Fruitless crown" (3.1) shows insecurity.

Scotland suffers beyond the palace. Malcolm's return contrasts national recovery with Macbeth's isolation.

6 A tragic ending

"Life's but a walking shadow" (5.5) empties life of substance; power has not brought meaning.

Macbeth still fights, but courage cannot cancel murder. Lady Macbeth's reported death limits what the audience knows.

An audience can feel horror, pity and relief together.